2.2. Origin and development of Settlement

Most anthropologists believe that humans first appeared in the Great Rift Valley of East Africa thousands of years ago. From there, they spread to the Middle East, Asia, Europe, America and Oceania. Neolithic Revolution (Agricultural Revolution) occurred in Mesopotamia, people went from hunter-gatherers and nomads to domesticators. The population grew relatively quickly. The emergence of urban population occurred also in some areas. Agriculture became especially successful largely in the river valleys of Nile, Ganges and Yangtze kiang.



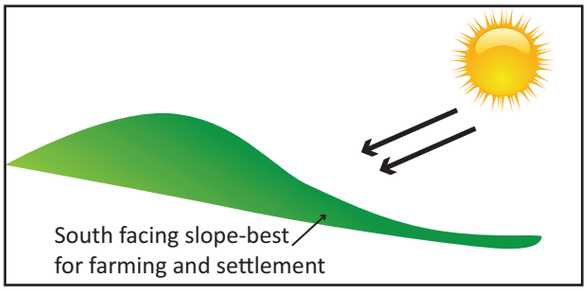
Harappa Settlement on the Indus river valley

These areas had fertile soil from annual flooding which led to abundant harvest. First cities arose in these areas and people were able to grow surplus food to feed a non-farming urban population thereby leading to specialization among the population. The priests, scribes, architects, farmers, soldiers, traders, blacksmiths, etc. were some other people ventured in these areas.

2.3. Site and Situation

Site

The Site of a settlement describes the physical nature of where it is located. Factors such as water supply, building materials, quality of soil, climate, shelter and defence were all considered when settlements were first established. For instance, the site of Sydney, in Australia, initially took advantage of the excellent natural harbour and surrounding fertile farmland.





Settlement in the south facing slope of the Alps

Aspect and shelter are two of the most important factors that were considered when deciding where to locate a settlement. Aspect relates to the direction in which the land faces. In the Northern Hemisphere the best slopes to locate on are those that face south, as they will receive the most sunshine, and therefore be the best for agriculture. This can be seen clearly in many of the valleys of the Alps, where settlements have located on the south-facing slopes.

Shelter is also very important, particularly from the cold northerly winds and prevailing south westerly winds in the UK. A good example of settlements being sheltered by their natural surroundings are the many spring-line settlements found along the base of the chalk escarpments of the North and South Downs. These settlements would also have benefited from the good water source and fertile farmland nearby.

TN_GOVT_XII_Geography_chapter2.indd 23 1/31/2020 10:39:04 AM